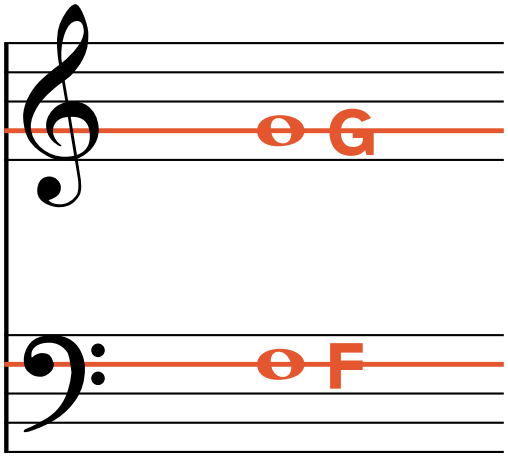
PART I · PITCH · 2

The staff and the clefs

Music is written on a **staff**: five lines and four spaces, counted from the **bottom**. Higher on the staff means higher on the keyboard. The **clef** at the start is the key to the code: it names one line, and every other note follows from it.

THE SECRET

The treble clef curls round G; the bass clef's two dots hug F.





Treble clef
curls round line 2: G

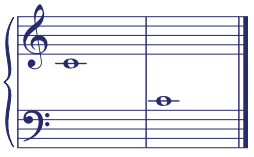


Bass clef
its dots hug line 4: F

Look closely: the treble clef curls round G · the bass clef's dots hug F

The grand staff

Piano music uses two staves joined by a brace: the **treble** staff on top, usually for the right hand, and the **bass** staff below, usually for the left. **Middle C** sits between them on a short line of its own, and can be written in either staff.

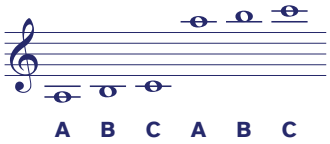


Middle C in the treble staff (left) and in the bass staff (right): the same key.

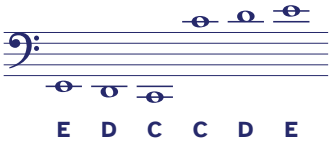
Ledger lines: the staff carried on

Notes too high or too low for the staff sit on short extra lines called **ledger lines**, spaced exactly like the staff lines. Read them by stepping on from the nearest staff line: line, space, line, space.

PART I · PITCH · 2 · CONTINUED



Treble: A, B, C below; A, B, C above.



Bass: E, D, C below; C, D, E above.

8va: play it an octave higher

Lots of ledger lines are hard to read. So a very high passage is written on the staff with **8va** and a dotted line above it: play those notes **one octave higher**, eight notes up, until the dotted line stops. **8vb** under the staff means an octave lower.

THINK OF IT A clef is a pair of glasses: the same five lines read as different notes, depending on which pair you put on.

EXAMPLE 1

One line, two notes

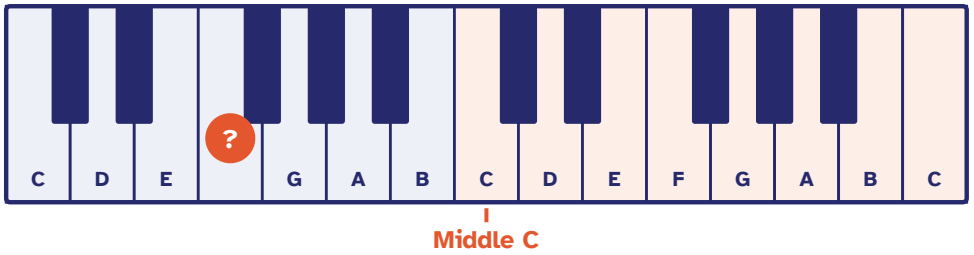


1. **Look at the red notes:** both sit on the bottom line.
2. **Now look at the clefs:** treble on the left, bass on the right.
3. **Read each from its clef note:** treble G is line 2, so step down (F in the space) to line 1; bass F is line 4, so step down line by line.

Treble bottom line: **E**. Bass bottom line: **G**. Same line, different note: always read the **clef** first.

EXAMPLE 2

Which staff is this key written on?



1. **Find Middle C.**
2. **Is the ? to its left or right?** Left is lower: the blue half.
3. **Low keys go on the bass staff**, high keys on the treble staff.

The **?** is below Middle C, so it is written on the **bass staff**, usually for the left hand.

PART I · PITCH · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Read a high note on ledger lines



1. **The top line** of the treble staff is F.
2. **Step up** one note at a time: G sits on top of the staff, A on the first ledger line.
3. **Keep stepping** to the red note: B above it, then the second ledger line.

Two ledger lines above the treble staff: **High C**, two octaves above Middle C.

GAME

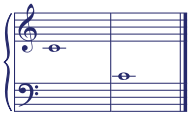
Treble or bass?

1	2	3	4
the E above Middle C	the lowest key on the piano	Middle C	High C

Which staff would each note be written on?

Answer: 1 treble · 2 bass, with ledger lines · 3 either · 4 treble, two ledger lines up.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
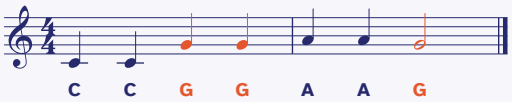


Point, then play.

Point to the line the treble clef curls round and play that G. Point to the line between the bass clef's dots and play that F. Middle C sits between them.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



The treble clef curls round **line 2: G**, the very note Twinkle leaps up to.

Try it. Point to the G line, then play C C G G A A G.

TRAP

× Reading bass-clef notes as if they were treble: check the clef on every line.

SEE ALSO

Reading the notes p. 30 · The staff and the keyboard p. 33

PRACTISE IT

Workbook Pitch 2 · Online: The Staff & the Two Clefs · Ledger Lines